

Greek philosophy



The beginnings of Western philosophy are closely linked to the rapid growth of Greek culture and society from around the sixth century BCE. In addition to mainland Greece and the Greek islands, Greeks had settled throughout the eastern Mediterranean, and southern Italy and Sicily. It was in one of these colonies, Miletus on the coast of modern Turkey, that the first known philosophers appeared. Led by Thales, the Milesian school of philosophy inspired subsequent generations, and the practice of philosophical thought and discussion rapidly spread across the Greek world. Athens proved to be the ideal place for philosophy to flourish, and produced perhaps the three most influential philosophers of all time – Socrates, Plato

and Aristotle. They were followed by four main schools of thought: the cynics, sceptics, Epicureans and stoics. Greek influence reached its height under Alexander the Great, but after his death in 323 BCE, Greece fragmented into conflicting factions and its cultural influence also waned, to be overtaken by the increasingly powerful Roman Empire.